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Draft translation - not yet human-reviewed / مسوده ترجمه

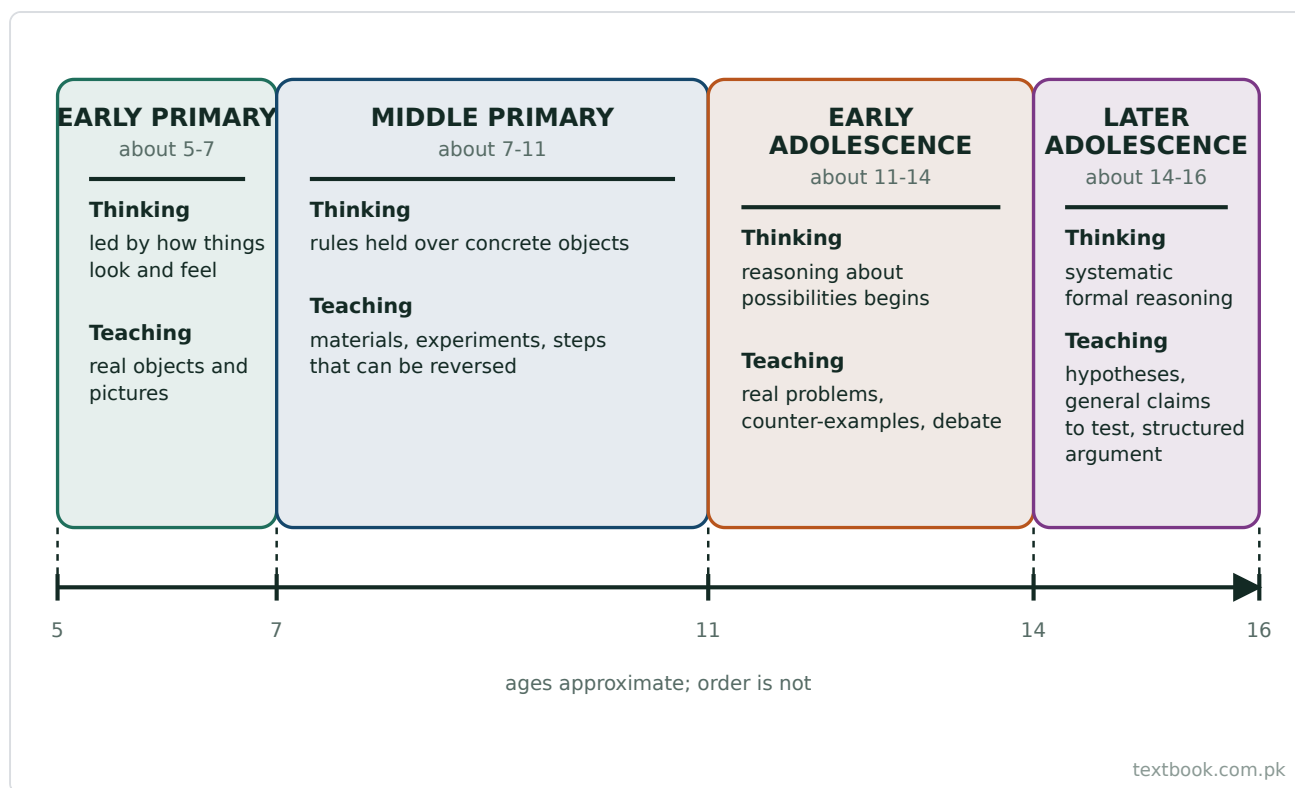
Topic 2.4 - Developmental stages and the classroom

A real classroom situation

Miss Shabana teaches Class 4 in a girls' primary school in Sukkur. Her fractions lesson was not working. She had drawn the fractions on the board as symbols - one half as $1/2$, one quarter as $1/4$ - explained the notation, and set sums. Half the class copied without understanding, and the other half did not even copy correctly.

A colleague from the B.Ed programme she attends at weekends suggested she start differently: bring rotis to class, actually break them, and let the pupils see and hold the halves and quarters before a single symbol appeared. She tried it. The lesson was noisier, slower, and - by the end - the pupils who could not previously touch fractions were arguing about whether two quarters really equalled one half, using pieces of roti as evidence.

The difference between the two lessons is not effort, discipline or ability. It is whether the teaching met the pupils at the stage their thinking had reached.



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Explanation

Developmental stages: reading age in stages

A **developmental stage** is a pattern of functioning that holds for a period and then gives way to the next in a fixed order. Topic 2.3 met Piaget's cognitive stages; other domains have their own (this course meets Erikson's social stages and Kohlberg's moral stages in later reading). What they share, and what earns the word "stage", is the package from Topic 2.1: same order for everyone, no skipping, each stage a real transformation of the last.

For a teacher, the stage idea is a **reading tool**, and it works in one direction only. Given a pupil's work or behaviour, you can read which stage the work is consistent with. You cannot run it backwards - from age to expectation - without breaking the rate principle, because ages are approximate and the spread inside any class is wide. The correct comparison for a pupil's work is **the stage descriptions, not the class average**.

Watch what that single change does to a staff-room judgement. "Bilqis is behind the class" compares Bilqis to sixty other pupils and says nothing actionable.

"Bilqis's answers are still led by how things look - she cannot yet hold the rule that pouring does not change the amount" locates her on a road everyone travels, names what she will be able to do next, and tells the teacher what to teach meanwhile. Same pupil, same work; the second reading has somewhere to go.

The stage reading also protects the teacher from the two classic errors.

Demanding the next stage early - abstract symbols before concrete experience, formal argument from ten-year-olds - produces copying without understanding, exactly the failure in Miss Shabana's first lesson. **Resting at the current stage forever** - concrete materials with a class ready for rules - produces boredom and misbehaviour from pupils whose thinking has moved on. The match is two-sided: the task must meet the stage, and the stage must be re-read as pupils move.

The misconception to clear now. "Stages are deadlines - a pupil who misses one is broken." No stage is ever skipped, and no pupil is ever stuck in one permanently (Seifert & Sutton, 2009). A Class 4 pupil answering like a Class 2 pupil is not damaged; the reading is that the concrete-experience side of the lesson is missing, and the remedy is to supply it. The stage vocabulary describes position on a road, and every road in this unit runs in one direction: forward.

Educational implications: matching teaching to development

The classroom consequences of this unit collect into a short list of moves a teacher can actually make.

Start concrete, then move to symbols. For any new concept, the order that matches development runs from handling or seeing the thing (rotis, water, counters), through pictures of the thing, to the symbols for the thing. Miss Shabana's second lesson is the pattern: break the roti, draw the roti, then write $\frac{1}{2}$. The order can be compressed for older pupils; it cannot be skipped for younger ones.

Check multi-step instructions against reversibility. A class that is not yet concrete operational can follow steps only in the order given, and loses the thread the moment a task asks them to double back (Seifert & Sutton, 2009).

The remedy is external: numbered steps on the board, a reminder to return to the story, a partner whose job is to track the place. The remedy is not repetition of the instruction at higher volume.

Give the fine-motor task a fine-motor page. Topic 2.2's motor order meets its classroom consequence here: wide-spaced lines and large letter boxes for the youngest, narrowing only as the control arrives. The page is cheaper than the pupil's confidence.

Read behaviour developmentally before reading it morally. The pupil who shouts when the group complains (Topic 2.3's activity), the pupil who cannot sit still after lunch, the pupil who cries at wrong answers: each has a developmental reading, and the developmental reading changes the response from correction to design. This is not permissiveness - the response still includes teaching the better behaviour - but it starts from "where is this pupil?" instead of "what is wrong with this pupil?"

Use the peer group, do not just police it. Group work is not a classroom technique only; it is a developmental opportunity, because negotiating a shared task is precisely the social rehearsal play used to provide. The isolated pupil the seating map reveals is the one for whom "work in groups" needs deliberate structuring - a role, a partner, a turn - rather than a general instruction.

Expect unevenness, and say so to the class. A class of sixty contains a spread of stages and rates. The teacher who names this openly - "some of you will get this today, some next week, and both are normal" - removes the shame that turns developmental difference into ability belief. Unit 6 of this course returns to what that shame does to motivation.

what you see in class	the developmental reading	a matched response
copying without understanding	the task is at a stage ahead of the pupils' thinking	back to concrete materials, then pictures, then symbols
multi-step instructions lost midway	reversibility not yet in place	numbered steps on the board, external reminders
large shaky handwriting despite effort	fine motor control still maturing	wider lines, larger boxes, patience
shouting when group work frustrates	emotional regulation still developing	a role in the group, a named strategy, time
one pupil always alone at break	the peer-group map has a gap	structured pairing, deliberate roles

Observe, read, respond Match the task to the pupil's next step.

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Activity: Match or mismatch

In pairs, about 20 minutes.

For each lesson choice below, decide whether it is **matched** or **mismatched** to the stage of its class, and name the principle from this unit that decides it.

1. A Class 3 teacher introduces multiplication with bundles of sticks before the times table.
2. A Class 2 teacher sets a comprehension worksheet with five instructions, the fifth of which says "go back to the passage and underline any word you used in answer 2".
3. A Class 6 teacher refuses to let pupils use fraction strips "because they are big enough to know fractions now".
4. A Class 1 teacher ends every writing period with a display of the neatest three books.
5. A Class 5 teacher gives the isolated pupil the job of materials manager for group work.

Then write the **one** you would change first, and the exact change you would make.

Check your understanding

1. Define a developmental stage in two sentences, naming the two properties that make a sequence of changes a stage sequence. (*Remember*)
2. Explain why a pupil's work should be compared to stage descriptions rather than to the class average. (*Understand*)
3. Name the two classic errors a stage reading protects a teacher from, with one classroom example of each. (*Understand*)
4. Miss Shabana's first lesson failed and her second worked. Using this topic's terms, explain exactly what changed and why it mattered. (*Apply*)
5. A colleague says "my Class 2 pupils are just careless - they lose track of the worksheet steps every time." Give the developmental reading and one matched response. (*Apply*)

Summary

A developmental stage is a period-bound pattern of functioning, occurring in a fixed order, never skipped. Read against stage descriptions rather than class averages, a pupil's work yields position and next steps instead of verdicts. The teaching that follows is matched rather than accelerated: concrete before symbolic, steps made external until reversibility arrives, pages that fit the fingers, behaviour read developmentally before morally, the peer group used as well as policed, and unevenness named as normal. The whole unit rests on the shift from "what is wrong with this pupil?" to "where is this pupil, and what is the next step from there?"

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

☐ I can define a stage and name the properties that make a sequence a stage sequence.

- ☐ I can explain why the stage reading runs one way only, and what the class average fails to give.
- ☐ I can list at least four matched-teaching moves and the principle behind each.
- ☐ I can take one real lesson choice of my own and say whether it is matched to its class, with reasons.

Try this at your practicum school

Take one lesson you will teach or observe this week and write down its single most important new concept. Then answer, in three lines: what will pupils **handle or see** of it, what will they see **pictures** of, and where does the **symbol** appear? If the symbol appears first, discuss with your cooperating teacher whether the order could be turned around.

Summative task

Write **250-300 words** analysing one lesson choice.

Choose a lesson you have taught, observed or received as a pupil, in which something was taught at the wrong level for the class. Describe the choice briefly, then analyse it: what the pupils' stage of development (in any domain from this unit) could and could not yet do, what the lesson demanded instead, and what the mismatch produced. Close with the redesigned version - the same content, matched to the stage - and name the principle that justifies your redesign.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong answer shows
Developmental analysis	The mismatch is located in a named domain and stage, not in a vague "too hard".
Matched redesign	The redesign is the same content taught in a different order or form, and the principle behind it is named.

Criterion	What a strong answer shows
	<i>(Analyze)</i>
Evidence discipline	The description of what the mismatch produced is drawn from the lesson described, not invented.
Plain, accurate writing	Terms used correctly; no padding; within the word count.

Further reading

- Seifert, K., & Sutton, R. (2009). *Educational Psychology* (2nd ed.), Chapter 3. University of Manitoba. CC BY.

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